Secretary Of Housing And Urban Development Visits Kansas City

By Jerry Walker

Mel Martinez, Secretary of the Department of Housing and Urban Development, visited an urban core neighborhood, Brooklyn Heights, on Wednesday, April 16.

Secretary Martinez toured the Georgetown Estates new housing development project in the area of 20th and Brooklyn.

The building of the new single-family housing is well underway, with many of the structures already completed.

The housing consists of three and four bedroom, two car garage units with full basements.

Numerous local community and political leaders were present. Also present were representatives of the builders, the finance community and government entities such as Fannie Mae(Federal Mortgage Corporation), originally the United States government administered commercial mortgage lender.

Fannie Mae is currently a New York Stock Exchange company and the largest non-bank financial services company in the world. It operates in accordance with a federal charter and is the nation's largest source of financing for mortgages.

Fannie Mae has mounted a concentrated effort to increase home ownership among low-income families living in the urban cores of our nation's cities.

Daniel H. Mudd, Fannie Mae's Vice Chairman and Chief Operating Officer, said, "We are very proud to participate in this broad-based effort to breathe new life into the Brooklyn Heights neighborhood."

Martinez said in his prepared comments that, "The focus for new housing developments such as Brooklyn Estates is to give the opportunity for home ownership and equity to minority communities. The goal set by the Bush Administration is to increase minority home ownership by five million by the end of the decade."

"The restoration, revitalization and beautification of communities like Brooklyn Heights provides unprecedented homeownership opportunities in a predominantly minority community, and is a demonstration of how the public and private sectors can work together to meet this challenge."

The Gabel Companies, a local private developer, was selected by the city as the builder in the Brooklyn Heights area.

During the past five years, Gabel has built 25 affordable homes in Brooklyn Heights.

The neighborhood is bounded on the north by 19th Street, on the south by 27th Street, on the east by Prospect avenue and on the west by Brooklyn avenue.

Total housing development in Brooklyn Heights is expected to reach 200 units over the next five years.

This effort is being coordinated by a broad-based partnership that includes HUD, Fannie Mae, The Gabel Companies, Douglas National Bank, and MOVE-UP.

Councilwoman Saundra McFadden Weaver and Councilman Troy Nash who represent Brooklyn Heights, addressed the gathered throng.

Councilman Nash said, "The successes in Brooklyn Heights are proof that the presence of safe and secure housing can dramatically alter the course of a city's future. A sense of community has re-emerged here, and Brooklyn Heights is beginning to flourish as a true urban neighborhood."



J.T. BROWN MEETS THE SECRETARY OF THE DEPARTMENT OF HOUSING AND URBAN DEVELOPMENT . . . Mel Martinez, the Secretary of the Department of Housing and Urban Development visited Kansas City on Wednesday, April 16. He is shown with J.T. Brown, MOVE-UP president, after acknowledging MOVE-UP's efforts in the urban core in a speech given at 20th and Park. - - CALL photo by George Murphy



NEW HOUSING IN THE URBAN CORE . . . The Georgetown Estates was the scene of the visit on Wednesday, April 16, by Mel Martinez, Secretary of the Department of Housing and Urban Development. The three and four bedrooms, two-car garage, full basement housing will soon be available for occupancy. This particular development is located in the Brooklyn Heights (20th Park) area. - - CALL photo by George Murphy



CITY COUNCIL MEMBERS SPEAK AT NEW HOUSING DEVELOPMENT . . . During the visit by Mel Martinez, Secretary of Housing and Urban Development, to a new housing development, Brooklyn Heights (20th and Park), on Wednesday, April 16, 3rd District City Council Members Troy Nash and Rev. Saundra McFadden Weaver offered comments. - - CALL photo by George Murphy